

Europeans Challenge

The end of the Vietnam War signaled lean times for the helicopter industry. Emphasis shifted to civilian machines, a sector buoyed by the expansion of the North Sea oil industry, but almost all were derivatives of military helicopters. An exception was Enstrom, which made small piston-engined personal helicopters. In Europe manufacturers in five countries competed in a tightening market.

▷ Mil Mi-24A Hind-A 1971

Origin USSR

Engine 2 x 2,200 shp Isotov TV3-117 turboshaft

Top speed 168 mph (270 km/h)

The crew of this escort and antitank helicopter sit in a glazed cockpit in front of a cabin for soldiers or casualties. Antitank missiles and rockets are carried on the wing and there is a gun in the nose.



△ Messerschmitt-Böelkow-Blohm MBB Bo105A 1970

Origin Germany

Engine 2 x 406 shp Rolls-Royce 250-C20B turboshaft

Top speed 168 mph (270 km/h)

The Bo105A was the first German-designed helicopter to enter production since WWII, and the first four- to five-seat twin-engined utility design with rear loading. Its titanium rigid rotor head and composite main rotor blades gave it remarkable maneuverability.



◁ Mil Mi-14 BT 1973

Origin USSR

Engine 2 x 1,900 shp Isotov TV-3 turboshaft

Top speed 143 mph (230 km/h)

The Mil Mi-14 was developed for the Soviet Navy as an amphibious antisubmarine and search and rescue helicopter. A mine-countermeasures version also entered service and was used in other countries including East Germany.

▽ SA Gazelle 1973

Origin France

Engine 590 shp Turbomeca Astazou IIIA turboshaft

Top speed 164 mph (263 km/h)

The Gazelle introduced the concept of a fenestron, or fantail—a ducted multiblade tail rotor. Entering service in 1973, it was used for observation, liaison, and pilot training roles.



△ Agusta-Bell AB206C-1 JetRanger 1974

Origin USA/Italy

Engine 420 shp Allison 250-C20 turboshaft

Top speed 137 mph (220 km/h)

Built under licence in Italy, the AB206 JetRanger found favour with both civil and military for a wide range of missions. The AB206C-1 upgrade can carry specialized equipment under hot and high-altitude conditions.

▽ Agusta A109BA 1976

Origin Italy

Engine 2 x 420 shp Rolls-Royce 250-C20 turboshaft

Top speed 193 mph (310 km/h)

Originally a light transport machine, the A109 first flew in 1971 and entered production in 1976. Later versions had military liaison, reconnaissance and antitank roles, and paramedic use.

